

FlowDesk

Live Installation Guide

Step-by-Step Guide for Installing FlowDesk
for a Live Client

Version 2.0

Updated from Shift Espresso live installation

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1. PRE-INSTALLATION CHECKLIST

Before visiting the client or starting remote setup, ensure all of the following items are prepared and confirmed.

Client Information Needed

- Business name and full address
- Opening hours (weekdays, weekends, holidays)
- Full product/service menu with prices (VAT-inclusive)
- Any business-specific info: Wi-Fi, pet policy, parking, special rules
- Contact person name and role
- Client's email address (for Meta/FlowDesk accounts)

Technical Requirements

- Client must have a **dedicated phone number** for WhatsApp Business (cannot be an existing personal WhatsApp number)
- The number must be able to receive SMS or voice call for verification
- Client needs a Facebook account with access to Meta Business Suite
- A valid payment method (credit/debit card) for Meta WhatsApp API billing
- A device (tablet/phone/laptop) for daily FlowDesk access

Prepare Before the Visit

- Generate QR code images (loyalty, ordering) with the client's number
- Draft the handover document with client-specific details
- Prepare the keyword automation texts (welcome, menu, hours, location, order, loyalty, support)
- Have the FlowDesk VPS accessible and tested

2. META BUSINESS SETUP (Client-Owned)

IMPORTANT: The Meta/WhatsApp Business account must be owned by the **CLIENT**, not by FlowDesk. This ensures the client owns their phone number, message history, and business verification.

Step 2.1: Create or Access Meta Business Account

- Go to **business.facebook.com**
- Client logs in with their Facebook account
- Create a new Business Portfolio (or use existing)
- Business name should match the real business name

Step 2.2: Create WhatsApp Business App

- In Meta Business Suite, go to **Apps**
- Click "**Create App**" and select "**Business**" type
- Name it clearly (e.g., "Shift Espresso WhatsApp")
- Add the "**WhatsApp**" product to the app

Step 2.3: Register the Phone Number

- In the WhatsApp product section, go to "**Phone Numbers**"
- Click "**Add Phone Number**"
- Enter the dedicated business number
- Choose verification method: SMS or Voice Call
- Complete verification with the code received
- Set the display name (e.g., "Shift Espresso Silvamonte")

Step 2.4: Create System User and Generate Token

CRITICAL: Do this while you have access to the client's Meta account. Facebook may block changes from new devices later.

- Go to **Business Settings > Users > System Users**
- Create a new System User (name: "FlowDesk Bot", role: Admin)
- Click "**Generate Token**"
- Select the WhatsApp app
- Grant permissions: **whatsapp_business_messaging, whatsapp_business_management**

IMPORTANT: This token does **NOT** expire. Copy and store it securely.

- If 2FA is required, complete it from the client's trusted device

Step 2.5: Add Payment Method

- Go to **Business Settings > Payments > Payment Methods**

- Add a credit/debit card
- This covers WhatsApp API messaging costs
- First **1,000 customer-initiated conversations** per month are FREE
- Business-initiated conversations (campaigns) have per-message cost

Step 2.6: Configure Webhook (FlowDesk Side)

- In the WhatsApp app settings, go to **Configuration**
- Set Callback URL: **<https://flowdesk.simplytranscriptions.co.za/api/webhook>**
- Set Verify Token: (use the FlowDesk webhook verify token)
- Subscribe to: **messages**, **messaging_postbacks**

Step 2.7: Business Verification (Optional but Recommended)

- Go to **Business Settings > Security Center > Business Verification**
- Upload **ONE** document: bank statement, utility bill, business registration, or tax certificate
- Processing takes 1-7 business days

Without verification: limited to **250 business-initiated conversations/day**. With verification: limit removed.

3. FLOWDESK WORKSPACE SETUP

Step 3.1: Create Client Workspace

- Log into FlowDesk admin
- Create a new workspace named after the client's business and location (e.g., "Shift Espresso Silvamonte")
- Set the client as workspace owner (using their Clerk account)
- Add yourself and team members as admins

Step 3.2: Configure WhatsApp Integration

In the workspace settings, enter:

- Phone Number ID (from Meta WhatsApp dashboard)
- WhatsApp Business Account ID (WABA ID)
- System User Access Token (from Step 2.4)
- Phone number (with country code, e.g., 27609778723)

Save and test the connection.

Step 3.3: Enable AI Assistant

Go to AI Settings and configure:

- Set business name
- Set business description
- Set tone (friendly, professional, etc.)
- Enable auto-reply: **ON**
- Set response delay if desired (e.g., 2-5 seconds for natural feel)

Step 3.4: Load Business Information

In AI Settings, populate these sections:

PRICING Section

Full menu with all prices (VAT-inclusive). Format each item clearly.

PRODUCTS/SERVICES Section

Ordering rules, pickup options, what can/cannot be ordered via WhatsApp.

FAQs Section

Opening hours, address (full: shop name, centre, street, suburb), Wi-Fi, pet policy, parking, any other common questions.

ADDITIONAL INSTRUCTIONS Section

Special rules like loyalty wording, size policies, staff handover triggers, welcome message format.

Step 3.5: Create Keyword Automations

Create these 7 standard automations:

1. Welcome Menu

- **Triggers:** hi, hello, hey, start
- **Response:** Welcome message with numbered options (1-6)

2. Our Menu

- **Triggers:** 1, menu, our menu, drinks, coffee
- **Response:** Full menu with each item on its own line, grouped by category

NOTE: Do NOT include "food" as a trigger -- food questions should go to AI.

3. Opening Hours

- **Triggers:** 2, hours, open, time, when
- **Response:** Full hours for weekdays, weekends, holidays

4. Location

- **Triggers:** 3, location, where, directions, address, find
- **Response:** Full address with shop name, centre, street, suburb

5. Place an Order

- **Triggers:** 4, order, pickup, collect
- **Response:** Instructions to send full order in one message

6. Loyalty

- **Triggers:** 5, loyalty, rewards, points, stamp
- **Response:** Loyalty programme details and how to join

7. Speak to Someone

- **Triggers:** 6, help, speak, agent, human, person
- **Response:** Confirmation that staff will respond, no footer

Footer Guidelines

- Most automations end with: **"Reply 4 to place an order, or ask me anything else."**
- Order automation ends with: **"Reply MENU to see our full menu."**
- Speak to Someone has **NO footer** (staff will respond directly)
- NEVER use "Reply MENU to go back" -- it doesn't make sense to customers

Step 3.6: Enable Client Mode

- Turn on **client_mode** for the workspace
- This gives the client/staff a simplified view (Inbox, Contacts, Orders, Loyalty, Campaigns, Daily Report, QR Codes)

- Admin users see the full admin view with all management tools
- Admin users get a **"Preview as Staff"** toggle to see the client's exact view

Step 3.7: Set Up Automated Backups

- Configure nightly database backup (2am default)
- 30-day retention
- Verify first backup completes successfully

4. TESTING CHECKLIST

Test **ALL** of these before declaring the installation complete. Do NOT message real customers during testing -- use your own phone numbers.

Customer Flow Tests

- "hi" → Welcome menu with numbered options appears
- "menu" or "1" → Full menu displays with each drink on its own line
- "hours" or "2" → Opening hours display correctly
- "location" or "3" → Full address with shop name, centre, street, suburb
- "4" or "order" → Order instructions appear
- "5" or "loyalty" → Loyalty programme info appears
- "6" or "speak to someone" → Staff handover message appears

Natural Language Tests

- "Where are you?" → AI gives full address (not just centre name)
- "What time do you close?" → AI gives correct hours
- "Pls send menu" → Keyword catches this (up to 5 words)
- "Do u have any food" → AI says coffee only, NOT the coffee menu
- "Do you have Wi-Fi?" → AI answers from FAQs

Order Tests

- "1 cappuccino" → Order parsed correctly with right price
- "1 latte with oat milk" → Extra price added correctly
- "2 cappuccinos extra hot" → Note captured and shown
- "1 flat white curbside" → pickup_type shows "curbside"
- "1 sandwich" → Politely declined, coffee only
- Order confirmation: YES → Order confirmed, NO → Order cancelled
- "2 cappuccinos and 1 iced latte" → All items parsed with correct total

Loyalty Tests

- Scan loyalty QR → Triggers join flow
- Give name → Immediately enrolled (don't wait for email)
- Skip email → Still enrolled, no issues
- Check stamp count displays correctly
- Verify "buy 9 get 10th free" messaging is correct

Admin Tests

- Changes in AI Settings take effect immediately (no restart needed)
- Changes in Automations page take effect immediately
- Admin view shows all tools
- Staff preview shows simplified view
- Orders appear on Orders page with all details (items, total, pickup type, notes)

5. HANDOVER PROCESS

Step 5.1: Create Staff Handover Document

- Login credentials (email, password, URL)
- What each section does (plain language, no jargon)
- Daily workflow (morning check, stamping coffee, handling orders)
- Key rules (AI runs 24/7, pickup only, etc.)
- Print and leave at the counter/tablet

Step 5.2: On-Site Training (if applicable)

- Show staff how to access FlowDesk on their device
- Walk through: checking inbox, viewing orders, stamping loyalty, sending campaigns
- Have staff send a test message and watch it appear
- Show how to manually reply when bot can't handle a question

Step 5.3: Admin Access Handover

- Ensure Meir/admin team has admin access on the live workspace
- Show how to switch between admin view and staff preview
- Explain which settings are editable from admin vs. need developer changes
- Provide QR code files and print-ready materials

6. THINGS TO WATCH OUT FOR

Technical Pitfalls

- Token generation **MUST** happen from a trusted device. Facebook blocks 2FA changes from new devices.
- The WhatsApp number cannot already be registered on personal WhatsApp. It must be a fresh or migrated number.
- Webhook URL must be HTTPS with valid SSL certificate.
- Engine deployment path matters: **/opt/flowdesk-engine/engine.mjs** (NOT /opt/flowdesk/engine.mjs).

Content Pitfalls

- Don't include "food" as a keyword trigger for the menu. Food questions should go to AI for proper handling.
- Don't use "Reply MENU to go back" -- use natural language like "ask me anything else".
- Keyword automations need footers that make sense from the customer's perspective.
- AI and keyword automations **MUST** have consistent information (same prices, hours, address).
- Remove the "food menu" synonym mapping if present in the engine.

Process Pitfalls

- Test with informal phrasing ("Pls send menu", "Do u have", "Where r u"), not just exact keywords.
- Client decisions **WILL** change during testing. Menu prices, size options, loyalty rules will evolve.
- Always have the client review the menu keyword automation text to confirm formatting and prices.
- Don't generate/edit AI-generated poster PNGs from compressed images -- work with originals or provide standalone QR codes.
- Business verification is optional but strongly recommended -- without it, campaign sending is limited to 250/day.

Data Safety

- Separate test and live workspaces completely.
- Rename old test/demo workspaces clearly (e.g., "Shift Dev/Test", "Shift Demo (Old Number)").
- Delete test orders before handover. Do **NOT** delete contacts, messages, loyalty members, or settings.
- Set up automated backups **BEFORE** going live.
- Old test workspace data must never leak into live workspace.

7. POST-INSTALLATION SUPPORT

First Week Monitoring

- Check daily for bot failures or unexpected responses
- Monitor order parsing accuracy
- Watch for customer messages that the bot handles poorly
- Adjust keyword triggers and AI rules based on real customer phrasing

Ongoing Maintenance

- Menu/pricing changes: Client edits from AI Settings and Automations pages
- New automations: Can be added from Automations page
- Bot behavior changes: May require engine updates for complex logic
- Backup verification: Periodically check that nightly backups are running

Escalation Path

Issue Type	Who Handles It	How
Prices, hours, FAQs	Client	Via admin panel
New features / logic	Developer	Engine / code update
WhatsApp API issues	Developer	Meta Business Suite, token, webhook logs
Server issues	Developer	Check VPS, restart services

This guide is based on lessons learned from the first live FlowDesk installation at Shift Espresso Silvamonte in June 2026. It will be updated as new installations reveal additional best practices.